



T20 WORLD CUP WIN PAVED WAY FOR SMOOTH TRANSITION IN WHITE-BALL CRICKET

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Irfan Pathan

Not many gave us a chance. It was the first edition of the game-changing T20 World Cup, and the Indian team was perhaps the least talked about, at least initially.

The seniors, Sachin Tendulkar, Rahul Dravid, and Sourav Ganguly, had withdrawn. Under the captaincy of a young Mahendra Singh Dhoni, we entered the unfamiliar terrain of white-ball cricket in the far-off land of South Africa.

By then, many of us — including Dhoni and Gautam Gambhir — had played quite a bit of international

cricket, and in no way were we inexperienced. However, even then, not many imagined that we would be able to master a format that was quick, tricky, and exciting.

However, as the tournament progressed, we not only proved people wrong but also ended up creating history by beating Pakistan to clinch the first-ever title. I will forever remember those moments in the final.

At the Wanderers that afternoon, Gautam played one of the finest innings to guide us to a competitive total and left it to us — the bowlers

— to defend it. It was challenging for sure, but every player was motivated to prove themselves, and that attitude brought the best out of us. While RP (Singh) provided those early breakthroughs, Pakistan still had partnerships by Younis Khan and Imran Nazir to rebuild, and there was a time when it looked as if we were slowly losing the grip.

As the crowd chanted our names and waved the tricolour, we bounced back. I am happy and proud to have played a hand in that historic victory. While Robbie (Uthappa) got Nazir run out, I swung into action with the three important wickets of Younis, Shoaib Malik, and Shahid Afridi. And with Afridi gone, we knew it was our match to lose. But Misbah-ul-Haq and Sohail Tanvir took charge and ensured a thriller.

To be honest, at one point, we believed that Misbah would lead the team to victory. However, we did not lose hope. Joginder, arguably, bowled the best spell of his career, and that one misjudgment by Misbah proved to be costly — it shattered Pakistan's chances and brought joy to millions of Indian supporters.

It was my first season after a long injury layoff, and the tournament turned out to be nothing short of a fairy tale. It instilled confidence in the young Indian cricket team and paved the way for a smooth transition in white-ball cricket.

The final was one of the biggest moments of our lives. However, our confidence received a boost after we defeated Pakistan in our second game via a bowl-out. It was also a special game for me because I bowled a maiden over and claimed a couple of wickets.

For the team, it gave us the belief that we could overcome any challenge. Our emphatic wins against England, South Africa, and Australia further bolstered our confidence and ensured we were on the right path. The rest, as they say, is history!

As told to Shayan Acharya